

Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD

Understanding and solving intractable resource governance problems.

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How to write the discussion section of an academic paper

This is one of the most challenging questions people have ever asked me, because after looking through dozens of journal articles in my Mendeley database, I could not find a lot of them who used Discussion sections. I believe this idea of the Discussion component of an academic journal article (or book chapter, in some cases) comes from the **IMRAD model of publishing**, that is, papers that have at least the following five sections: Introduction, Methods, Results, Analysis and Discussion (hence the acronym).

Personally, I neither like, nor do I often write this type of journal article. Even when I was a chemical engineer, I can't recall that I read many papers in the IMRAD model, as they all had a variation (merging Discussion with Results, or Results with Conclusion, or Discussion with Conclusion). As I said on Twitter, I read engineering, natural science and social science literatures. Thusly, the Discussion sections that I read vary QUITE A LOT.

HOWEVER

All Discussion sections I've read are

1. analytical, not descriptive,
2. specific in their interpretation of research results,
3. robust in their linkage of research findings with theories, other empirical reports and various literatures,
4. good at explaining how a paper's results may contradict earlier work, extend it, advance our understanding of X or Y phenomenon and, most definitely:
5. NOT the conclusion of the paper.

What I think is important to remember when writing the Discussion section of a paper, is to really ANALYZE, not just describe. Link theories, methods, data, other work.



Dr. Raul Pacheco-Vega

@raulpacheco

Replying to @raulpacheco

My post on the difference between Description and Analysis should help you write Discussion sections. raulpacheco.org/2017/05/distin... you should all read Graf and Birkenstein's They Say/I Say raulpacheco.org/2017/05/they-s... as preparation to write Discussions - for the rhetorical moves. </fin>

2:56 PM · Mar 14, 2019



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As usual in my blog posts, I here link to a few resources that may be of help (written by other authors).

- > Dr. Pat Thomson, as usual **providing great advice on Results/Discussion sections of journal articles**.
- > A handy handout on **what goes in each of the IMRAD sections**.
- > Note how **this article** by Sollaci and Pereira on 50 years of IMRAD articles does NOT have a Conclusion section (oh, the irony!). However, their Discussion section is quite nice, albeit brief.
- > This article by Høfler et al offers **good advice on integrating substantive knowledge with results** to create a solid Discussion section.
- > In this article, **aner ?ani?** and coauthors provide great suggestions on **how to write a Discussion section** of a journal article.

In my Twitter thread, I suggested ways to discern (and learned from) how authors have written their discussion sections.

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About Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD

I am a Full Professor with the Methods Lab at the Facultad Latinoamericana de Ciencias Sociales (FLACSO) Sede Mexico. My research is interdisciplinary by nature, and I identify both as a political scientist and as a human geographer, the two fields in which I trained during my doctorate. For a long time, my work centered [...]

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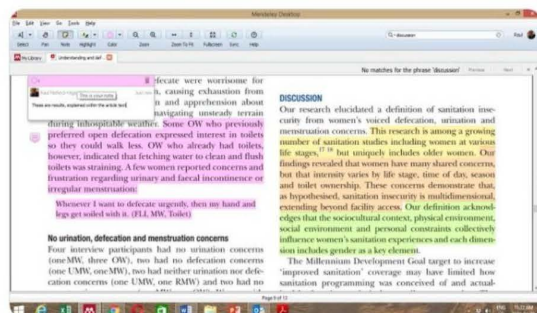


Dr Raul Pacheco-Vega · Apr 9, 2019

@raulpacheco ·

Replying to @raulpacheco

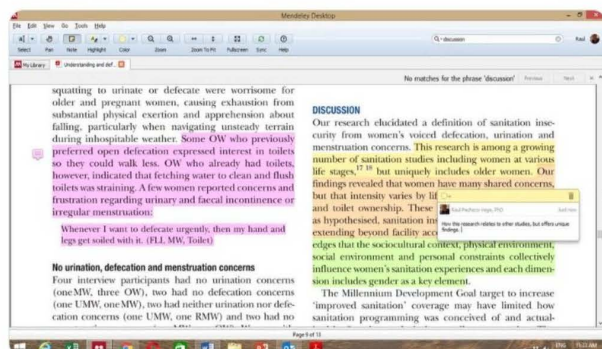
Continuing my thread on "How to Write Discussion Sections". Note how the authors of this paper offer snippets of data (see my pink highlights) and explain those results in the "Results" section, but elaborate on how these results support/disprove their hypothesis/findings.



Dr Raul Pacheco-Vega

@raulpacheco ·

If you now read the Discussion section, you'll see that in my yellow highlights, I've noted how this particular article contributes to the literature. This is part of what should go in the Discussion section. More than explaining results, how your results link to broader debates.



5:24 AM · Apr 9, 2019



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Dr Raul Pacheco-Vega

@raulpacheco ·

Replying to @raulpacheco

Discussion sections are particularly used in articles that follow the IMRAD model ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC2706822/ I like this Power Point on what should go in each of the IMRAD sections jgpmonline.com/documents/authenticity/ - what I've found is that often times, Discussion sections are blended/morphed

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The introduction, methods, results, and discussion (IMRAD) structu...

Background: The scientific article in the health sciences evolved from the letter form and purely descriptive style in the seventeenth...

5:29 AM · Apr 9, 2019



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There are times when scholars blend Discussion and Conclusions, or Results and Discussions sections. This is not even discipline-dependent, it's author-dependent.

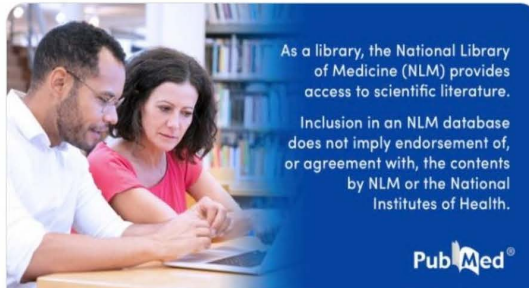


Dr Raul Pacheco-Vega · Apr 9, 2019



@raulpacheco ·

I read very broadly (across humanities, natural sciences and social sciences) so I don't always have articles in the IMRAD model to showcase particular elements of a paper. But the ones that usually have them are those focusing on sanitation, like this one [ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/29071131](https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/29071131)



pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov

Understanding and defining sanitation insecurity: women's gendered experiences of urination,...

To sincerely address women's sanitation needs, our finding...



Dr Raul Pacheco-Vega

@raulpacheco ·

For example, in this [#Free2DownloadAndRead](#) World Development article, the discussion section is blended with the results.

[sciencedirect.com/science/articl...](https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/...) This is common, and I personally have no objection to doing this. As for PhD dissertation and discussion chapters: this is challenging

5:35 AM · Apr 9, 2019



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Another example, now from the criminal justice field.

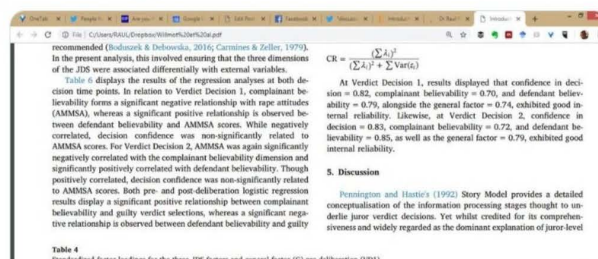


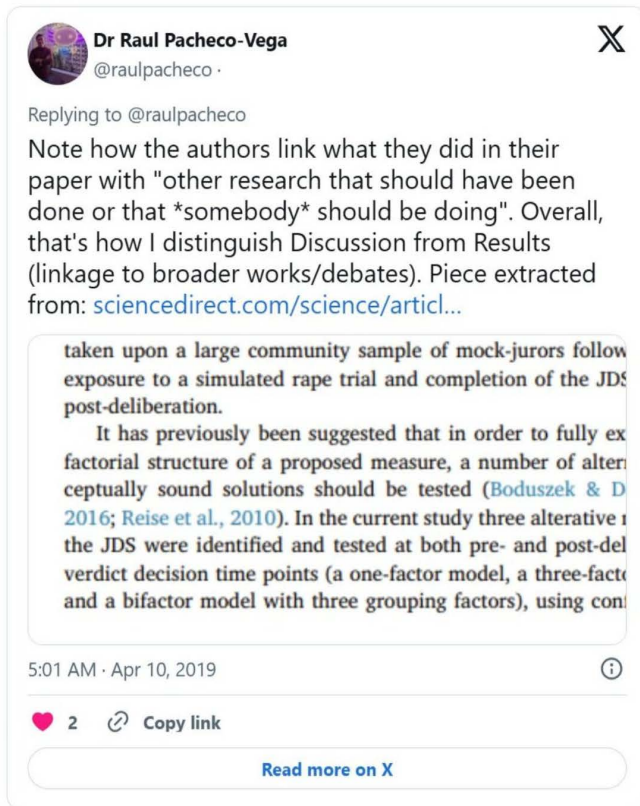
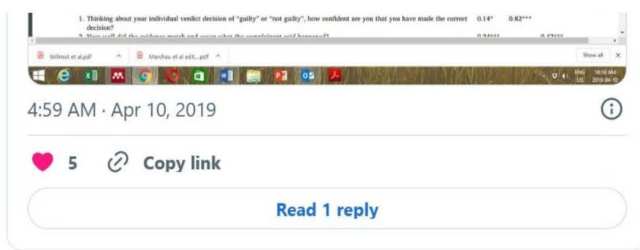
Dr Raul Pacheco-Vega



@raulpacheco ·

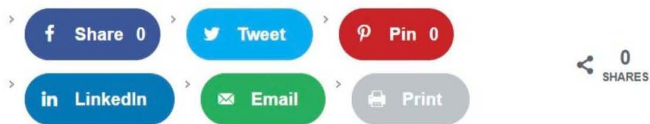
If you notice how these authors start their Discussion section, you'll see that they bring back their empirical results to the broader debates. That's what I have seen in most Discussion sections of journal articles (in engineering, public health and some psych).





Hopefully these notes will be helpful to fellow scholars writing these sections!

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By [Raul Pacheco-Vega](#) – April 10, 2019

rev="post-6570" 2 comments



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